Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

May 7, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S17 -- 2000 Model Year Ford F-650 and F-750 Trucks -- Tie Rod and Drag Link Replacement

Summary

- Ford Action -- Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving the steering linkage of certain 2000 model year F-Series medium trucks. Based on notification provided to Ford by the supplier, certain tie rod and drag link ball sockets may have been improperly heat treated. F-650 and F-750 medium trucks with the affected components were built at the Cuautitlan Assembly Plant from July 26, 1999 through October 29, 1999. In addition, a small number of 7000 and 8000 Series medium trucks were built at the Ford of Venezuela Valencia Assembly Plant between July 31, 1999 and December 31, 1999.

- Number of Vehicles Involved -- 4,267 vehicles (4,101 in the United States, 146 in Canada and 20 in Venezuela).

- Affect on Vehicle Operation -- The ball socket on the affected vehicles may wear prematurely and allow the ball stud to separate from the socket. If this occurs on the tie rod, the remaining tie rod will allow the vehicle to be steered safely to a stop. If it occurs on the drag link, a loss of steering control may result. Ford is not aware of any reports of ball stud separation on Ford vehicles, or of any reports alleging that a fire, accident, injury, or fatality occurred.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will inspect the date code on the tie rod ends and drag links. Although only seven percent of the sockets used to produce the tie rod ends and drag links built during the suspect time frame are believed to be improperly heat treated, all tie rod ends and drag links with suspect date codes will be replaced.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S17 5d/rjw/ae

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S17 -- 2000 MODEL YEAR FORD F-650 AND F-750 TRUCKS -- TIE ROD AND DRAG LINK REPLACEMENT

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

Certain 2000 model year Ford F-650 and F-750 medium trucks built at the Cuautitlan Assembly Plant from July 26, 1999 through October 29, 1999 are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

The tie rod ends and drag link assemblies mentioned later in this report were supplied to Ford by TRW Commercial Steering Division, 902 Lyons Road, Portland, Michigan. TRW's phone number is (517) 647-4121.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 4,100 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Approximately seven percent.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

The ball socket on certain tie rod ends and drag link assemblies may have been improperly heat treated. Improperly heat treated ball sockets could wear prematurely and result in a separation of the ball stud from the socket. This condition could potentially result in either a tie rod separation which will allow the vehicle to be safely steered to a stop, or in a drag link separation which could result in a loss of steering control. Ford is not aware of any reports of tie rod or drag link separations on Ford vehicles, or of any reports alleging that a fire, accident, injury, or fatality occurred.

May 7, 2001

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

Ford first became aware of this condition when notified of a potential defect in the tie rod ends and drag links by the supplier on February 9, 2001. Subsequent analysis revealed that only tie rods and drag link assemblies with either 9G2 or 9G3 date codes are affected. The condition was traced to a malfunction in the heat treat process. Shipping records at the supplier and the assembly plant were used to identify the production dates when the suspect parts were likely to have been used in production.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford will notify owners of record of affected vehicles to return vehicles to dealers for inspection of the date codes on the tie rod ends and drag link assemblies. Parts with suspect date codes will be replaced. This service will be performed at no charge to owners. Ford currently anticipates that owner notification will occur on or before the week of June 4, 2001. In addition, dealers will be advised to return any service parts with suspect date codes.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. Notices to dealers and owners from Ford Customer Service Division will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S17 to this action.